

PLAYGROUNDS

The purpose of this policy is to establish general standards for playground design and construction, maintenance, equipment use, approval processes, and funding within Loudoun County Public Schools (LCPS). The Division Superintendent is authorized to promulgate regulations to implement this policy as needed.

Playgrounds provide an important benefit not only to students within LCPS but also to the broader community. Although playgrounds are not formally part of physical education instructional programs within the LCPS curricula, having a safe and cognitively and physically stimulating place to play, commonly used during recess during school hours and by the public during non-school hours, is an important part of overall student well-being.

A. Playground Equipment.

1. Inclusive playgrounds, age-appropriate for 5 to 12-year-olds and age-appropriate for 2 to 5-year-olds, shall be installed, when space and funding permit, as part of new elementary school construction and as part of the LCPS standard for elementary schools. Inclusive playgrounds should be located within a fenced area, when space allows.

2. When any playground equipment is installed on School Board property, the Board assumes ownership of that equipment unless specifically stated otherwise by agreement. For this reason, the maintenance of playground equipment installed by a school or community group is the responsibility of the School Board.

3. Once equipment is installed on School Board property, the principal of the school has the responsibility to inspect the equipment and surrounding area for visible defects, accessibility, and general usability on a regular basis and the authority to order its repair or removal from the school property. The principal may also restrict or deny the use of such equipment until such time as, in their opinion, it is restored to a safe condition.

B. Design and Construction.

1. All elementary schools will be equipped with a playground with a minimum standard of equipment as established by the School Division. Additional playground equipment and play areas are permitted to be established at elementary schools through school or community organizations, in accordance with this policy and Regulation 6320: Playgrounds and in coordination with the school principal. At the discretion of the Department of Support Services, playgrounds may be established on other LCPS facilities in support of specific instructional programs.

2. Playground equipment constructed at LCPS facilities should comply with generally accepted state and national playground safety guidelines, found in the Virginia Department of Education's *Guidelines for School Facilities in Virginia's Public Schools* and Consumer Product Safety Commission's *Public Playground Safety Handbook*, as well as related standards published by the American Society for Testing and Materials

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(ASTM) and International Play Equipment Manufacturers Association (IPEMA). These guidelines enhance the safety of students and community members using the play equipment and are based on well-established research and best practices.

3. Playground equipment constructed at LCPS facilities should be designed to create a cognitively and physically stimulating recreational place appropriate for elementary-age students (ages 5-12) - or preschool students (ages 2-5).

4. Safety considerations for playground equipment include both the actual composition of the play equipment (particularly maximum fall height) and the depth and characteristics of the surface material to prevent critical injury. Playground equipment constructed at LCPS facilities must have a head injury criterion (HIC) score no greater than the level specified in the relevant ASTM standard. IPEMA certification is required for all equipment and surfacing used at LCPS facilities.

5. LCPS playgrounds will be compliant with the Americans with Disabilities Act of 1990 (ADA), as amended. Additionally, efforts shall be made to install accessible and inclusive playground equipment within each LCPS Planning District, such that children of different abilities can play together. All additions or replacement projects for full playgrounds undertaken with LCPS-managed funding will be inclusive playgrounds. Inclusive playgrounds include features that make them welcoming, safe, and enriching spaces for all children, such as accessible play equipment, unitary rubber safety surfacing, a variety of sensory experiences and challenges, swings, seating, multi-level ramped play structures, a variety of play panels, a communication board, motion-oriented equipment such as spinners or rockers, accessible wide routes throughout the playground, and a clear layout.

6. All equipment shall be marked with the appropriate age range for safe use. Playgrounds should be clearly marked to identify characteristics of responsible equipment use and limits of liability.

C. Maintenance.

1. All playground equipment and associated playground surfacing on LCPS property, regardless of its method of procurement or construction, is owned and maintained by the School Division.

2. Playgrounds and playground equipment shall be properly maintained and routinely inspected by school staff, and annual inspections conducted by a third-party for compliance with applicable safety standards. Additional play equipment installed through outside funding will be removed when it reaches end of life and not replaced by LCPS. Playground surfaces must maintain accessible routes and remain reasonably cleared of hazards and an appropriate minimum depth of surface infill material periodically maintained and/or replaced.

3. Concerns over playground or playground equipment safety should be

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reported to the school administrator and subsequently to the School Division through established protocols.

4. Playgrounds or playground equipment that are unsafe shall be restricted from use until repaired, permanently removed and/or replaced in a timely manner at the discretion of the School Division.

D. Equipment Use.

1. Since playgrounds and playground equipment are designed for use by children, adult supervision is required at all times they are in use.

2. Use of playgrounds and associated playground equipment is intentionally designed and prioritized for use by LCPS students at the school at which the playground is located. Therefore, during school hours they are closed to the public and under the direct supervision of school staff. During school hours, use of playgrounds and associated playground equipment by students should be reasonably monitored by school personnel for appropriate use. School staff are responsible to ensure that playground equipment is used appropriately and in accordance with established protocols by the manufacturer.

3. Outside of school hours, playgrounds are open for use by the public at the discretion of the Department of Support Services.

4. Risk of injuries resulting from the use of equipment is assumed by the user and/or child's parent or legal guardian.

E. Approval Process and Funding.

1. New playgrounds should be part of the original design and approvals of the new school facility and built to an established standard developed by the School Division and funded through the Capital Improvement Program (CIP).

2. Replacement of entire playgrounds or specific equipment should be done at the discretion of the Department of Support Services to enhance safety, efficiency, effectiveness and/or fulfillment of this policy, to previously referenced established standards, and funded through the Capital Asset Preservation Program (CAPP), operating budget, or other LCPS-managed funding, as deemed appropriate.

3. Playground equipment modifications or additions funded through school or community organizations should be proposed and coordinated through the school administrator and in accordance with guidelines and processes established by the School Division and consistent with this policy.